

See also: The Peace of Westphalia 94–95 ■ The Hague Conventions 174–177 ■ The United Nations and International Court of Justice 212–219 ■ The Universal Declaration of Human Rights 222–229 ■ The International Criminal Court 298–303

was engaged in the Second War of Italian Independence. By chance, Dunant arrived just as the Battle of Solferino, one of the bloodiest battles of the 19th century, was coming to an end. Almost 5,000 soldiers are known to have died, with more than 23,000 wounded and many others missing. The suffering and neglect on the battlefield affected Dunant so strongly, he was inspired to write *A Memory of Solferino*, in which he not only described the horrors of war but also proposed suggestions as to what he saw as the solution—an international, volunteer-led group to take care of the wounded.

Dunant's clarion calls for an international body to protect the victims of war led the *Société genevoise d'utilité publique* (Geneva Society for Public Welfare) to appoint a committee of five, including Dunant, to explore whether this idea was viable. The group met for the first time in Geneva early in 1863 as the International Relief Committee for Injured Combatants (IRCIC). The IRCIC convened a conference

in Geneva in October that year. Delegates from 16 states and four philanthropic organizations took part. They adopted initial resolutions on the humanitarian treatment of wounded combatants.

First Geneva Convention

In 1864, at another Geneva conference, the earlier resolutions were adopted as the First Geneva Convention for the Amelioration of the Condition of the Wounded in Armies in the Field, which was later abbreviated to the First Geneva Convention. Its key provisions were: protection from capture of all injured and sick soldiers; impartial treatment of all captured combatants; protection for all civilians providing aid to the wounded; and recognition of the symbol of the red cross on a white background as identifying people and equipment covered by the »

At the Battle of Solferino in 1859, many wounded and dying soldiers were shot or bayoneted to death rather than receiving medical treatment as they lay on the battlefield.



Henry Dunant

Born in Geneva in 1828, Henry Dunant devoted much of his life to humanitarian issues. In 1859, while traveling in Italy, he witnessed the terrible aftermath of the Battle of Solferino. Horrified by the treatment of the injured, he campaigned for the creation of a neutral body to help those wounded on the battlefield. His work led to the creation of the International Committee of the Red Cross and the First Geneva Convention in 1864.

Later, Dunant became bankrupt and was shunned by Genevan society, but that did not stop him from continuing to campaign on humanitarian issues, including the idea for a universal international library and the codification of rules concerning prisoners of war. After some years in obscurity, Dunant was recognized in 1901 as the first recipient of the Nobel Peace Prize, yet died in poverty in 1910.

Key work

1862 *A Memory of Solferino*

